

BRIDGING THE GAP AND HOW!

The exceptional performances of **energetic and determined young chess players** have elevated India's reputation to unprecedented levels.

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In recent times, rarely has so much happened in one calendar year for India. With chess icon Viswanathan Anand passing the torch to the younger generation, 2023 brought an abundance of positive news. It stood out in how the global chess community perceives India. The exceptional performances of energetic and determined young players have elevated India's reputation to unprecedented levels.

Who could have imagined five Indians in the top-level Candidates tournaments, determining contenders for the next World title in both sections? It's noteworthy that this includes the first sister-brother duo participating in their respective Candidates events, held at the same venue.

Four Indians were in the quarterfinals — and no Russian — in the World Cup, and one of them challenged the eventual champion Magnus Carlsen in the final. Some truly sensational individual performances in what turned out to be the most followed chess event on Indian news channels. In short, the country woke up to chess. R.

Praggnanandhaa became a household name — the first after Anand — and continues to be the new flag-bearer for the followers of the sport in India.

In terms of the rise on the world ranking list, another teenager, D. Gukesh, made the chess world sit up and take note. He briefly displaced Anand as the highest-rated Indian in any published world ranking list in 37 years after gate-crashing into the elite top 10.

Not just that. Gukesh went on to beat Anand twice in his debut on the Grand Chess Tour: in the SuperUnited Rapid and Blitz in Croatia. The year 2023 also saw Gukesh win the World Chess Armageddon Asia and Oceania title by beating former World Rapid Champion Nodirbek Abdusattorov (Uzbekistan) in the final.

The Grand Swiss event is considered the strongest Open event in the sport. To expect an Indian to win the Open section was not unreasonable. But the way Vidit Gujrathi and R. Vaishali made it an Indian sweep and booked their places for the Candidates was simply sensational.

By the time the year ended, Gukesh and K. Humpy had joined the trio by taking different routes. With

the women's World No. 1 Hou Yifan not interested in playing the Candidates, Humpy made it based on being the next highest-rated non-qualifier on the world list.

Gukesh, second to an already-qualified Fabiano Caruana on the FIDE Circuit points table, occupied the eighth and last spot.

As a result, when the Candidate tournaments are held in Toronto, Canada, in April, Praggnanandhaa, Vidit, and Gukesh will represent India in the Open section and Vaishali and Humpy in the women's section. This kind of presence in the Candidates has brought India more respect and recognition than what one witnessed after India claimed medals in both sections of the 2022 Chess Olympiad.

The presence of 11 Indians in the top 100 of the world ranking list was also unprecedented. Though by the end of 2023, Gukesh and Anand were elbowed out of the top-10 list, it was gratifying to see that every 11th player on the elite list was an Indian.

Anand (11), Praggnanandhaa (13), Vidit (14), Arjun Erigaisi (17), Gukesh (25), P. Harikrishna (33), S. L. Narayanan (42), Nihal Sarin (43), Aravindh Chithambaram (72), Raunak Sadhwani (83), and Abhimanyu Puranik (96) stood in this order.